

# Mandarin Chinese *ma*:

## Q morpheme, SA intensifier, or PQP?

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### Introduction

(2) *Dayal's (2021) left periphery*  
[<sub>SAP</sub> SA° [<sub>PerspP</sub> PQP [<sub>CP</sub> Q [<sub>TP</sub> ...

### Question morpheme

Japanese *ka* is an example Q morpheme (Cheng 1991). It can be embedded by both responsives and rogatives:

- (3) Eren-wa [Mikasa-ga ocha-o  
Eren-TOP Mikasa-NOM tea-ACC  
nonda **ka**] shitteimasu.  
drank Q knows  
'Eren knows if Mikasa drank tea.'
- (4) Eren-wa [Mikasa-ga ocha-o  
Eren-TOP Mikasa-NOM tea-ACC  
nonda **ka**] shiritai desu.  
drank Q want.to.know is  
'Eren wants to know whether Mi-  
kasa drank tea.'

Mandarin *ma* is not like Japanese *ka*. It can only be embedded by rogatives:

- (5) John \*(xiang) zhidao [xia yu le  
John want know fall rain PRF  
**ma** zuotian].  
MA yesterday  
'John wants to know/\*knows if it  
rained yesterday.'  
(Bhatt & Dayal 2020: 1122)



(1) Xia yu le (ma)?  
fall rain PRF MA  
'Did it rain?'

Is *ma* a Q morpheme?

No.

Is *ma* an SA intensifier?

No.

Is *ma* a PQP?

Maybe!

### Speech act intensifier

Li (2006) and Kim (2019) propose that the yes-no question (YNQ) marker *ma*<sub>1</sub> and the evidentiality marker *ma*<sub>2</sub> are the same morpheme:

- (6) *Kim's (2019) proposal*  
*Ma* intensifies speech acts.  
a. *Ma*<sub>1</sub> only occurs in YNQs.  
b. *Ma*<sub>2</sub> never occurs in YNQs but occurs in declaratives, imperatives and *wh*-questions.

However, unlike *ma*<sub>1</sub>, *ma*<sub>2</sub> never embeds:

- (7) \*John zhidao [xia yu le ma<sub>2</sub>].  
John know fall rain PRF MA<sub>2</sub>  
Int.: 'John knows that it rained.'

### Polar question particle

Hindi *kyaa* is a PQP (Bhatt & Dayal 2020, Dayal 2021). It cannot be embedded by responsives but can be *quasi-subordinated* (Dayal & Grimshaw 2009) by rogatives:

- (8) \*ravi jaantaa hai [ki **kyaa** anu  
Ravi know is that PQP Anu  
jaaegii].  
will.go  
Intended: 'Ravi knows if Anu will go.'  
(Dayal 2021: 9)
- (9) ravi jaannaa caahtaa hai [ki  
Ravi know want is that  
**kyaa** anu jaaegii].  
PQP Anu will.go  
'Ravi wants to know whether Anu will go.'  
(Dayal 2021: 34)

Mandarin *ma*'s distribution is similar.

### Open question

Why is more than one *kyaa* or *ma* disallowed in a sentence?

- (10) \*John xiang zhidao [xia yu le  
John want know fall rain PRF  
**ma**] **ma**?  
MA MA  
Int.: 'Does John want to know if it rained?'